

TOTAL LOK SABHA SEATS 29

	BJP	INC
2024	29 (59.3%)	0 (32.4%)
2019	28 (58%)	1 (34.5%)
2014	27 (54%)	2 (34.9%)

Vote share in ( )



ANI

27 seats—the two seats of Guna and Chhindwara, then represented by Jyotiraditya Scindia and Kamal Nath, respectively, the only ones to hold out against the BJP onslaught. By the next election, Guna too succumbed as Scindia, who contested from here as a Congress candidate, lost, and a year later, joined the BJP. Chhindwara remained the last Congress soldier on that battlefield, electing Congress candidate and Kamal Nath's son, Nakul, to Parliament. This year, Scindia retained Guna, though as a BJP candidate, but Chhindwara stood felled, contributing to the perfect score of the BJP.

The BJP, which had won the state election only a few months earlier, went into the Lok Sabha election with the strategy to dominate its rival psychologically. Part of this strategy was to engineer mass defections in the Congress. The party also specifically targeted Chhindwara, according to party insiders, ensuring mass defections of corporator- and booth-level Congress leaders here, to alter voting patterns. "The victory in Chhindwara is an outcome of the booth-level strategy that was put in place before the assembly election. Also, the people in Chhindwara were yearning for a change," says V.D. Sharma, state BJP president. The Congress, in comparison, "did not contest the election as a party", observes political analyst Girija Shankar. "After polling in Chhindwara was over on April 19, Kamal Nath did not really pitch in for party candidates by campaigning for them. Some support by senior leaders and party could have helped in seats where the party was in the contest," he adds.

The Congress now has four years to build a base in MP if it hopes to challenge the well-entrenched BJP in the next assembly election

THE CONGRESS DECLINE

No one would have predicted this rout in the lead up to the election, though. Political observers, in fact, believed the Congress to be a serious contender in more than half a dozen seats in the state—Bhind, Morena, Satna, Gwalior, Rajgarh, Chhindwara, Mandla and Ratlam. In these seats, the party was banking either on the draw of senior party leaders, local candidates or traditional vote banks like tribals, to pull through. However, while the Congress did manage to bring down the margin of votes by which it lost in Bhind, Morena, Gwalior, Rajgarh and Satna, it failed to win even a single seat in the state.

The Congress's disappointing performance in MP may reflect poorly on state Pradesh Congress Committee (PCC) president Jitu Patwari, who was appointed to the post in December last year. What could act as a positive is that the poor results could relegate veteran leaders like Kamal Nath, Digvijaya Singh and Kantilal Bhuria to less demanding positions, leaving the filed open to fresh faces and strategies and, hopefully, better results. Patwari, meanwhile, has his task cut out. He has four years to build the party's base if the Congress hopes to challenge to the well-entrenched BJP in the 2028 assembly polls. Talking to INDIA TODAY, the PCC president said, "The results in Madhya Pradesh are naturally disappointing for the Congress and they call for a complete overhaul of the old working style. In the days to come, you will see a radical change in the way the Congress party functions in the state." MP could well do with a wind of change to dispel any musty odour that may set in. ■